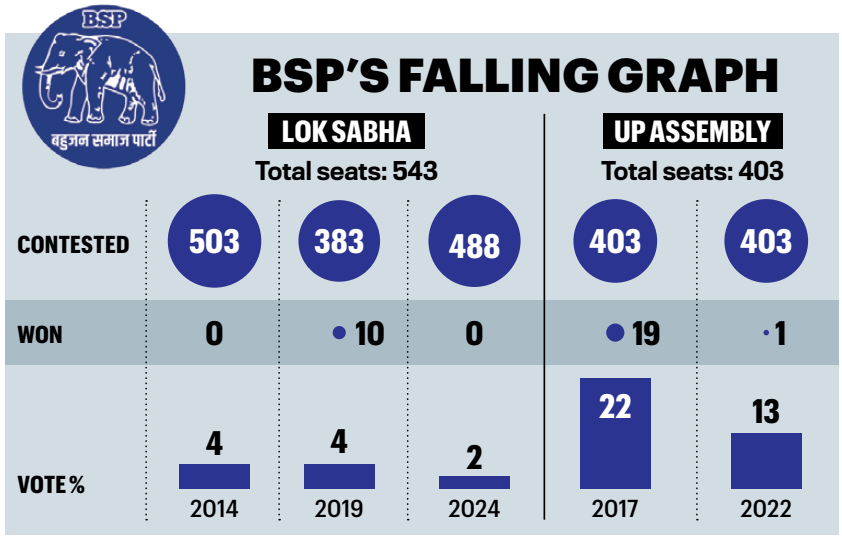


posts on X, Mayawati made it clear that she remained the rightful leader of the party. Harking back to her mentor and party founder Kanshi Ram, she wrote that the BSP as "a party and movement" was rooted in the ideology of one who "sacrificed everything" for B.R. Ambedkar's humanitarian ideals. "In this movement, personal interests, relationships, and ties hold no significance—only the welfare of the Bahujan community is paramount."

Sacrifice, though, seemed furthest from her own mind as she dispelled notions of a successor waiting in the wings. "Now I myself have also taken this decision that till my lifetime and till my last breath, I will not have any successor in the party. The decision was welcomed wholeheartedly by the people of the party," she wrote on X. This was a more categorical statement than her earlier assertion, "Just as Kanshi Ram Ji did, during my lifetime as well, the true successor of the party and movement will be the one who, like a devoted disciple of Kanshi Ram Ji, dedicates themselves wholeheartedly—enduring every hardship—to advancing the party and the movement with unwavering commitment."

Thus Mayawati laid to rest any ambiguity about Akash inheriting the BSP mantle. Her relationship with her nephew had been souring for a while. The BSP supremo had removed him as national convenor last year, though she later reinstated him. Her disenchantment with him perhaps began with his aggressive anti-BJP stance during the Lok Sabha election when he openly attacked the ruling party over issues like paper leaks, inflation, and unemployment, while Mayawati has trained her fire mostly on the Congress and the Samajwadi Party in recent years.

MAYAWATI HAS REMOVED NEPHEW AKASH FROM ALL PARTY WORK AND EXPELLED HIS FATHER-IN-LAW ASHOK SIDDHARTH. HER MOVES HAVE LEFT BSP CADRE CONFUSED

However, the concentration of power now is becoming a source of worry in the party. Though centralised decision-making has its advantages, Mayawati's poor calls on a variety of issues are feeding perceptions of unpredictability, fuelling internal instability and casting doubts on the party's strategic direction. It's a long list of perceived missteps, starting from parting ways with the SP despite electoral gains, refusal to join the Opposition INDIA bloc, her growing insecurity and alienation of people once close to her and being seemingly oblivious to the rise of Chandrashekhar Azad as an alternate Dalit icon. Past allegations of corruption and legal challenges—such as the disproportionate assets cases and controversies over public expenditure on monuments—have not ceased haunting her either.

All of this is reflecting in voter mistrust and a sense of the BSP's declining electoral viability as an independent entity. In the 2014 general election, the party scored a duck—the BJP and allies won 73 out of UP's 80 seats, the Congress and SP won two and five, respectively. In 2019, the SP-BSP alliance helped the BSP gain 10 seats even as the SP retained its five. Post the split, the SP's trajectory went upward—it won 43 seats in the 2024 Lok Sabha election, halting the BJP juggernaut—and the BSP back to a nil tally.

Once a kingmaker, the BSP's failure to make electoral gains even in areas with a substantial Dalit population is now threatening its long-term prospects. While Congress claims that the Dalit vote has shifted towards INDIA, SP leaders argue that their party has become a natural alternative for the Dalit voters. Several former BSP leaders, including three former state presidents, have switched sides; 13 of the SP's 37 MPs are of that stock. Elsewhere, multiple factions within the BSP are working at cross-purposes during elections. In Delhi, party insiders claim five distinct factions operated separately, weakening the party's cohesion and electoral prospects.

In the state that it once dominated, the BSP's decline is spurring realignments in the political landscape. New Dalit leadership, is emerging, like Azad's Aazad Samaj Party, even as the SP and Congress consolidate their position. As the BSP's vote share continues to dwindle, it is becoming increasingly uncertain who the party is fighting against or aligning with. Mayawati may still be at the helm, but the BSP ship seems rudderless. ■